Rich Churcher

Senior Platform / SRE

+64-21-126-3919
rich.churcher@gmail.com
/richchurcher
/bas-ie

Profile

Senior platform and site reliability engineer with 8+ years shipping and operating production systems on Linux and AWS.

Second career after 14 years as a paediatric intensive care nurse, including flight transport — I bring clinical incident-response discipline to production operations: calm under load, bias to root cause, triage what matters first.

Self-taught, remote-first, and happiest in small teams where autonomy and pragmatism matter more than process.

Skills

Cloud / Infra	AWS (EC2, ECS, EKS, Lambda, RDS, DynamoDB, Kinesis, IoT Core, EventBridge), Terraform, Spacelift, Kubernetes.
Languages	Go, Python, TypeScript, Rust, Bash, sundry others.
Platform / CI	GitHub Actions, CircleCI, Concourse, Docker, Linux (Arch, Amazon, various other flavours), Postgres, MySQL.
Observability	Datadog, Grafana, CloudWatch, New Relic, Sentry; incident management and on-call design.
Data	Athena, Redshift, Mage, ETL pipeline migration.
AI workflow	Claude Code in daily workflow; CodeRabbit and Copilot integrated into PR review pipelines; agent-assisted migration and code archaeology.
AI infrastructure	Local inference via ollama (Qwen3-Coder). MCP servers to GitHub, AWS. Developer tooling for ops workflows.

Experience

Multitudes — Nov 2025 - Mar 2026 (Contract)
Software Engineer — *Remote*

- Implemented Okta/Autho enterprise SSO.
- Updating and migrating data ingestion and processing workflows using Mage and Athena.
- Claude Code daily driver for exploration, diagnostic helper, documentation automation, compressing ramp-up on an unfamiliar codebase within a short contract window.

Basis — Oct 2024 – November 2025
Site Reliability Engineer — *Remote*

- Created an incident management plan for a complex production environment that included IoT, mobile, and cloud services components.
- Migrated an ECS-based datalake stack to Kubernetes.
- Migrated the terraform-based IaC environment from Terraform Cloud to Spacelift.
- Claude Code in daily workflow, Copilot integrated into PR review pipelines to raise baseline review quality and catch regressions earlier.

Lightspeed Commerce — Oct 2023 – Oct 2024
Senior Platform Engineer — *Remote*

- Wrote automated tooling in Go to traverse hundreds of GitHub repositories to update versions and configuration values.
- Implemented a custom GitHub runner to launch ops tasks in the production environment (database maintenance, new Kafka topics), reducing maintenance time and unblocking developer workflows.

Cogo Dec 2022 – Oct 2023
Senior Platform Engineer *Remote*

- Reduced development environment costs by more than half in some cases using Terraform to conduct timed teardowns via GitHub Actions.
- Increased the observability of costs across AWS accounts using Python and the AWS API.
- Negotiated, planned, and rewrote on-call and incident management documentation, making the on-call engineering experience safer and more predictable.
- Troubleshoot CI, deployment and runtime issues in a containerised Elixir (Phoenix) environment.

Spidertracks Apr 2021 – Dec 2022
Senior Software Engineer *Remote*

- Mapped network ingress from Iridium satellites and cellular devices through legacy infrastructure to mitigate Java server load issues.
- Rebuilt on-call team and ops culture from the ground up after company was acquired.
- Centralised scattered observability across New Relic, Grafana, CloudWatch, Sumologic, and Sentry, laying groundwork for a single-pane-of-glass migration.

Eventfinda Nov 2020 – Apr 2021
Senior Software Engineer (Contract) *Remote*

- Assisted with and advised on upgrading a large existing codebase (React, PHP).
- Improved test coverage of legacy code in order to avoid regressions when migrating to newer systems.

BuildSpider Sep 2019 – Nov 2020
Senior Software Engineer (Contract) *Remote*

- Wrote extensive Postgres functions and migrations as part of a GraphQL API using Postgraphile.
- Added a secure S3-backed file library feature using React, Relay, and role-based permissions using Postgres row-level security.

HYPR Innovation Feb 2019 – Sep 2019
Senior Software Engineer (Contract) *Remote*

- React/MobX frontend and Node/Kafka microservices processing animal data for a large agricorporation.

Hylo Mar 2017 – Aug 2018
Software Engineer (Contract) *Remote (San Francisco)*

- React Native mobile app for a distributed SF-based team; performance and deep-linking work.

Earlier contract and teaching roles (2015 – 2018): 2015 – 2018

- Enspiral Dev Academy, Saatchi & Saatchi, BKA Digital Outfitters — React, Node, curriculum design.

Paediatric Intensive Care Nurse 1999 – 2015
Starship Hospital (Auckland) & Children's Hospital at Westmead (Sydney).

- PICU flight transport team, ECMO team.

Projects

Bucket Apr 2022 – Jan 2025
Senior Software Engineer (Volunteer) *Remote*

- Sole developer and platform engineer for Fairground Foundation, working on Bucket, an environment crowdfunding application.
- Go, Flutter, Figma, Terraform, AWS. Low-cost strategies for a pre-launch product.

Education

Otago Polytechnic 1996 – 1998
Bachelor of Nursing *Dunedin*